

Francisco J. Laso Peñaherrera

Environmental Studies, Western Washington University · Bellingham, WA

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EDUCATION:

- 2021** **University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.** Chapel Hill, NC
Ph.D. in Geography.
- 2013** **Erasmus Mundus Masters Programme in Evolutionary Biology**
University of Groningen. Groningen, Netherlands
Université Montpellier 2. Montpellier, France
Masters of Science in Evolutionary Biology, Erasmus Mundus Scholar
- 2008** **Columbia University, Columbia College.** New York, NY
Bachelor of Arts in Ecology, Evolution, and Environmental Biology

SELECTED ACADEMIC PUBLICATIONS:

- Benitez, F. L., Mena, C. F., **Laso, F. J.**, Zapata, M. B., Rivas-Torres, G., & Gobin, A. (2026). Trajectories of farming systems reshape land use/land cover dynamics in the agricultural zones of the Galapagos Islands. *Agricultural Systems*, 231, 104506. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.agsy.2025.104506>
- Walsh, S. J., **Laso, F.J.**, & Giefer, M. (2024). Animals and Land Cover/Land Use Change: A Remote Sensing—Galapagos Islands Assessment. In *Reference Module in Earth Systems and Environmental Sciences*. Elsevier. <https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-443-13220-9.00004-4>
- Laso, F.J.** Arce-Nazario, J. (2023). [Mapping Narratives of Agricultural Land Use Practices in the Galapagos](#). In *Island Ecosystems, Social and Ecological Interactions in the Galapagos Islands* (pp. 225–243). Springer Nature Switzerland. ISBN: 978-031-28088-7
- Pike, K. Blake, S., Gordon, I., Cabrera, F., Rivas, G., **Laso, F.J.**, Schwarzkopf, L. (2022). Navigating agricultural landscapes: responses of critically endangered giant tortoises to farmland vegetation and infrastructure. *Landscape Ecology*, 0123456789. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10980-022-01566-x>.
- Laso, F.J.** (2020). Galapagos is a Garden. In S. J. Walsh, D. Riveros-Iregui, J. Arce-Nazario, & P. H. Page (Eds.), *Land Cover and Land Use Change on Islands* (pp. 137–166). Cham, Switzerland: Springer Nature Switzerland AG. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-43973-6_6
- Laso, F.J.**, Benítez, F. L., Rivas-Torres, G., Sampedro, C., & Arce-Nazario, J. (2020). Land Cover Classification of Complex Agroecosystems in the Non-Protected Highlands of the Galapagos Islands. *Remote Sensing*, 12(65), 1–39. <https://doi.org/10.3390/rs12010065>

RECENT AWARDS AND GRANTS:

- 2025** **Writing, Research, and AI Faculty Fellowship.** Year-long faculty fellowship focused on developing critical AI literacy and integrating generative AI tools into teaching and research
- 2025** **COIL Faculty Fellowship.** Selected to receive training (\$1200) for integrating Collaborative Online International Learning (COIL) into curriculum Development at WWU.
- 2023** **Diversity & Social Justice Grant.** Award (\$6000) for Mapping access and disability at Western’s campus.
- 2020** **Melinda Meade Award for Excellence.** Semester-long award (\$10,000) from UNC Geography Dept. for dissertation completion that covers tuition and healthcare for Fall semester.
- 2018** **Russel E. Train Fellowship.** Competitive two-year fellowship (\$30,000) from World Wildlife Fund for supporting PhD research on human-environment interactions in the Galapagos Islands at UNC.

SELECTED CONFERENCE ACTIVITY:

- Laso F.** A Través de la Garúa: ¿Qué tanto de las zonas agrícolas de Galápagos alcanzan a ver satélites? *Paper presented at the VIII Simposio de Investigación y Conservación en Galápagos, Puerto Baquerizo Moreno, Galápagos, Ecuador. (2026).*
- Laso F.** [Mapeando el Futuro Energético del Ecuador: Localización de Reactores Modulares con GIS.](#) *Guest speaker at the Simposio Internacional Energía Nuclear en Ecuador, Quito, Ecuador. (2025).*
- Laso F.** Mapping Accessibility Project: Updates and setting new objectives. *Presentation at Working Session at the Disability Studies and Action Collaborative Annual UnConference. Bellingham, WA. (2025)*
- Laso F.** Hunt. C. [“New” Geographies of Islands: Extracting Global Lessons from Island Microcosms.](#) *Session organized at American Association of Geographers (AAG) Annual Meeting. Honolulu, HI. (2024)*

SELECTED RESEARCH EXPERIENCE:

- 2022 – Present** **PI:** [Galapagos Agroecological Observatory](#) - WWU. Galapagos, Ecuador. Conducted collaborative and interdisciplinary research about how to balance food production with environmental conservation.
- 2021 – 2022** **Post-doctorate fellow: Community monitoring of oil pollution in the Amazon.** USFQ. Quito, Ecuador. Analyzed reports from community monitoring program and assessed risk from oil spills in the northern Amazonian region of Ecuador. Sup. Carlos Mena.
- 2021 – 2022** **Image specialist, Center for Galapagos Studies.** UNC Chapel Hill, NC. Compiled and catalogued spectral images for research collaboration in Galapagos. Sup: Philip Page
- 2015 – 2021** **[Ph.D. Dissertation: Food, Wildlife, and Land Use in the Galapagos Islands.](#)** UNC Chapel Hill, NC. Conducted transdisciplinary research related to the interconnections between agriculture and conservation in the Galapagos Islands. Combined qualitative and quantitative data analysis to untangle the physical, socioeconomic, and biotic drivers that affect farmers livelihoods as well as endemic species conservation. Sup. Dr. Stephen Walsh.
- 2018 – 2021** **Research Assistant: Synthesis of Drivers & Patterns of LCLUC in Island Ecosystems.** Funded by NASA Land Cover and Land Use Change (LCLUC) Program. PI: Dr. S. Walsh

SELECTED TEACHING & PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE:

- 2022 – Present** **Assistant Professor: Environmental Studies, WWU.** Bellingham, WA. Designed and taught: Intro to GIS, Cartography and Geovisualization, Advanced GIS Applications, Extractivism and its Alternatives in Latin America, Understanding Environmental Data and Information, Introduction to Research Methods, Navigating the Human Experience: Postmodernism, Introduction to Remote Sensing.
- 2020 – 2021** **Online Teaching Coach, UNC Chapel Hill.** Chapel Hill NC. Trained UNC Geography faculty in online teaching methods and tools as part of an ad-hoc Online Teaching Committee. Advised faculty and facilitated the construction of online courses through regular office hours and LMS templates. Developed UNC [Geography's Online Teaching Website](#). Sup: Dr. Elizabeth Olson.
- 2014 – 2015** **Field Instructor: Ecology Project International.** Galapagos, Ecuador. Taught 10 day-long field outings with local and international high school students in the Galapagos Islands. Activities included mark-recapture of giant tortoises, seed dispersal analysis, tortoise nesting ground protection, invasive species management, tortoise breeding center maintenance, data collection and scientific project design with students. Sup: Ana Maria Loose

SELECTED SERVICE AND VOLUNTEERING EXPERIENCE:

- 2023 - Present** **Lead Coordinator:** [Mapping Accessibility Project \(MAP\).](#) WWU. Bellingham, WA. Organized GIS students into collaborative projects with the Digital Technologies Accessibility Coordinator and the Disability Outreach Center that pursue cartographic projects to advocate improving physical accessibility on campus as well as enhancing access to geographic information.